arrival of Subramania Siva, a twenty-six-year-old youth in the ochre robes of a sanyasi. Angered by the deportation of Lala Lajpat Rai and Ajit Singh, Siva had followed political developments with a keen interest and was converted to the Swadeshi fold. As news of the Swadeshi fever in Tuticorin reached him in Trivandrum, he dashed off a letter to VOC and, without waiting for a reply, set out on foot to join the fray. Reaching Tirunelveli on 9 January, he promptly delivered a public lecture. In the following weeks, he travelled all over the district speaking at Ambasamudram, Kallidaikurichi, Sivakasi, Srivilliputtur and Tenkasi. The core themes of Swadeshi ideology—indigenous enterprise, boycott of foreign goods, the need for national education—found vigorous expression in his speeches. Condemning the Arms Act that prohibited the carrying of weapons by Indians, Siva underlined the need for physical fitness and training for youths. With Siva's arrival in Tuticorin in the first week of February, the fuse was lit to the Swadeshi powder keg.

Staying as a house guest of VOC, Siva delivered lectures on the seafront 'almost daily through February'. After two years of constant travelling, VOC, now stationed in Tuticorin, presided and/or spoke at all these meetings. In a few weeks, another young man, S. Padmanabha Aiyangar, also from Trivandrum, arrived and gave his first public talk on 28 February. Swadeshi propaganda now reached a feverish pitch. Even the police who were prone to lower assessments of anti-government crowds estimated that people gathered in the thousands. The pejorative language used by the police to describe the character of the crowds—the mob, riffraff, the unlettered, etc.—indicates that the common people, cutting across class, caste and sect, were mobilized.

In the words of Bernard Bate, Tuticorin was 'set … alight in oratorical incandescence'.[12] In his path-breaking work on Tamil oratory, Bate further argues that the Swadeshi lectures constituted 'the first *systematic* use of vernacular [Tamil] political oratory to the common people'. As a result, 'a new kind of [political] imaginary was born'.[13] The Tamil language had now been forged into a vehicle of political communication shaping democratic practice for the next century and more. The speeches, delivered in Tamil,